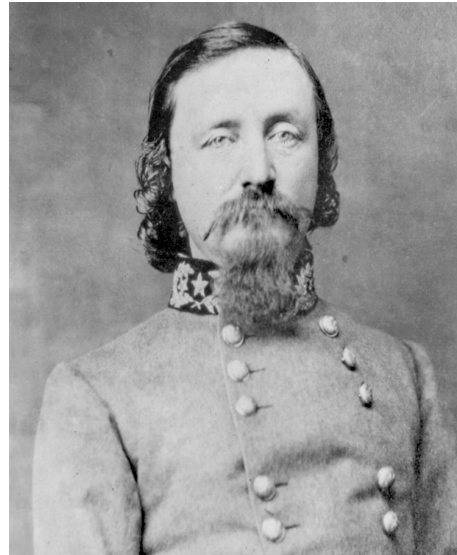


CONFEDERATE GENERAL (1825-75)

GEORGE EDWARD PICKETT

A native Virginian born into a wealthy family of enslavers, Pickett saw service on the Western frontier and in the War with Mexico. As a Confederate, he fought at Gaines' Mill and commanded a division at Fredericksburg. He led his Virginia troops in the fateful Pickett's Charge at Gettysburg on July 3, though he did not originate the plan. Pickett served until the end of the war with limited success. What he lacked in tactical knowledge he made up for with a dashing personality that made him a favorite with subordinates and superiors alike.



Repelled and defeated

Most of Pettigrew's and Trimble's shredded commands disintegrated before they reached Cemetery Ridge, but a few joined the remnants of Pickett's division as about 200 Southerners jumped over the stone wall, planted their flags on the Union position, and fought hand-to-hand using clubbed muskets and bayonets. A few of Hancock's regiments were overrun and started to turn for the rear, but timely reinforcements bolstered the Union line and prevented the breakthrough.

Brigadier General Lewis Armistead, one of Pickett's commanders, fell while leading his men with his hat on the tip of his sword, minutes after his old friend Hancock had been wounded. The men who followed him were killed, wounded, or captured. Pickett's charge had failed. Through the smoke, survivors trudged back to Seminary Ridge. Lee greeted some of them, and lamented, "All this has been my fault."

In the evening of July 4, the Army of Northern Virginia began its long retreat back to the safety of Virginia. Leaving in a downpour, it wound its way west across the South Mountain to Chambersburg,